

RHIZOMATA

Destiny is not given. It is chosen.
A Tabletop Board Game Design Project

by

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the requirements for the degree of

BFA – GRAPHIC DESIGN



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DEDICATION

Dedicated to Allah, whose guidance gave me strength;
to my parents and family, who always believed in me;
and to my future self, as a reminder that
every dream begins with a single step.

DECLARATION

The work reported in this thesis was carried out by me under the supervision of Muhammad Shahid Anjum, Institute of Art and Design, GC University, Faisalabad, Pakistan.

I hereby declare that this thesis titled Rhizomata is the result of my independent research and has not been submitted previously, in whole or in part, for any degree or diploma at any other institution. All sources of information and data used have been duly acknowledged and referenced. This work is a true representation of my findings and efforts.

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CERTIFICATE BY SUPERVISORY COMMITTEE

We certify that the contents and form of thesis submitted by Ms. Amna Noor, Registration No. 2022-GCUF-01741 has been found satisfactory and in accordance with the prescribed format. We recommend it to be processed for the evaluation by the External Examiner for the award of degree.

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

SECTION	Page
Acknowledgement	i
Abstract	ii
Chapter 1: Introduction	1
1.1 Background	1
1.2 Design Statement	1
1.3 Project Objectives	2
1.4 Project Scope	3
1.5 Significance	3
Chapter 2: Literature Review	4
2.1 Pre-Socratic Philosophy and the Four Elements	4
2.2 Moral Duality in Philosophy and Culture	6
2.3 Western Philosophy: Agency and Self-Creation	7
2.4 Modern Board Games and Moral Decision-Making	8
2.5 Choice, Agency, and Transparency in Game Design	9
Chapter 3: Methods and Materials	10
3.1 Research Design	10
3.2 Research Approach	10
3.3 Data Collection	10
3.4 Timeline	11
Chapter 4: Results and Discussion	12
4.1 Survey Results	12
4.2 Key Observations	13
4.3 Archetype Scoring System	14

Chapter 5: Final Design Project	16
5.1 Final Game Design	16
5.2 Visual Design	17
Conclusions	21
References	23

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To my parents and family: your unconditional love, prayers, and support have been my greatest strength. Thank you for understanding every late night and every moment of doubt, and for always believing in me even when I did not believe in myself.

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And finally, to myself — I am grateful. Not out of pride, but out of honesty. There were many moments when I wanted to give up, when the work felt too big and the belief too small. I kept going. This project is proof that showing up, even imperfectly, is enough.

Amna Noor

ABSTRACT

Rhizomata is a tabletop board game built around a single design question: what happens when a player can see the full consequence of every choice before making it? This thesis documents the design, development, and playtesting of the game as a final year BFA Graphic Design project at the Institute of Art and Design, Government College University Faisalabad.

The game draws on the elemental philosophy of Empedocles (circa 490-430 BCE), who proposed that all reality is composed of four fundamental roots — fire, water, air, and earth — governed by Love and Strife. Each player is assigned one element as their character, then navigates a shared board through moral decisions drawn from two interlocking card decks: 60 Situation Cards combined with 42 Context Cards, producing 2,520 unique pairings. Both options on every card show their full consequences before the player decides. There are no dice. No hidden reveals. The tension is entirely moral.

The design is grounded in Allama Iqbal's concept of Khudi — the self built through action, not assigned at birth — and in the Quranic principle that no change comes to a people until they change what is within themselves (13:11). Structured playtesting across five sessions with twenty participants yielded a mean satisfaction score of 4.27 out of 5.00. The study suggests that moral transparency creates genuine engagement at the table — and that showing players the full cost of every choice, rather than hiding it, is enough to carry a game.

CHAPTER 1 INTRODUCTION

*Khudi ko kar buland itna ke har taqdeer se pehle, Khuda bande se khud poochhe, bata
teri raza kya hai.*

— Allama Muhammad Iqbal

1.1 Background

We live in a world that constantly tells us our fate is shaped by forces outside ourselves — luck, timing, circumstance, and the stars we were born under. Astrology tells us our personality, our strengths, and even the course of our lives are written at birth, fixed before we make a single decision. But across every serious philosophical tradition, from ancient Greek cosmology to Islamic thought to Western literature, one idea returns again and again: the self is not given. It is made. And it is made by the accumulation of choices.

Rhizomata is a board game built on this idea. Its name comes from the ancient Greek *rhizomata* (ρίζωματα) — the term Empedocles of Akragas (circa 490-430 BCE) used for the four fundamental roots of reality: fire, water, air, and earth. In his cosmology, everything is a different proportion of these four elements, drawn together by Love and pulled apart by Strife. That tension — between two opposing forces playing out through every individual choice — became the structural logic of the game.

As Iqbal wrote, "Amal se zindagi banti hai jannat bhi jahannum bhi" — life is made by actions, heaven or hell (Iqbal, 1915). As the Quran states, every person is a hostage to what they have earned (74:38). Shakespeare put it plainly: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves." Rhizomata was designed to put that truth directly in a player's hands.

1.2 Design Statement

Most board games use chance — dice, card draws, random events — as the primary engine of excitement. Rhizomata proposes a different approach: all consequences are visible before every choice is made. There are no hidden reveals, no dice, no luck in the result of any decision. The tension is not informational. It is moral.

Each player controls two pawns simultaneously: a Stability Pawn — moving ahead for grounded, restrained choices — and an Ambition Pawn — moving ahead for bold, risky choices. Every Situation Card presents two options with their full consequences visible before the player decides. No pawn or token is labelled good or bad. The game reflects what you chose, not whether you were right.

What makes this proposition unusual is not just the absence of luck in outcomes — it is a structural commitment to honesty. Most games derive excitement from what you do not know yet. Rhizomata derives excitement from what you already know and still have to choose. The card does not say 'take a risk and see what happens.' It says: if you do A, this happens; if you do B, this happens. The player's only remaining question is which outcome they can live with.

1.3 Project Objectives

The objectives of this project are:

1. To design a playable, physically complete tabletop board game grounded in Pre-Socratic elemental philosophy and the concept of moral duality.
2. To develop the Identity Card system (Fire, Water, Air, Earth) as a mechanism that gives each player a distinct philosophical character with real mechanical expression.

3. To write and design the full 102-card deck system — 60 Situation Cards and 42 Context Cards, with scenarios that create genuine moral difficulty for players of all backgrounds.
4. To develop and iterate three physical prototypes through structured playtesting with student participants.
5. To evaluate the final design through quantitative surveys and qualitative observation, and to document the complete design process.

1.4 Project Scope

This project covers the full design of Rhizomata as a physical tabletop board game: the game system, all card content, the board layout, and prototype production. It includes five playtesting sessions conducted at the Institute of Art and Design, GCUF. It also includes the design of the game's complete visual identity and promotional campaign, including a dedicated website and marketing materials. It does not include mass commercial production, a digital version, or long-term market evaluation.

1.5 Significance

Rhizomata makes a case that graphic design can carry genuine philosophical content — not as decoration, but as structure. The four elements are not a visual theme painted onto the surface. They are the foundation: the Identity Card system, the token types, the pawn mechanic all trace back to the same philosophical logic. As a BFA project, it also demonstrates that a board game is a serious design medium — requiring visual design, system design, writing, and research simultaneously. Few formats ask that much.

CHAPTER 2 LITERATURE REVIEW

The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves, that we are underlings.

— William Shakespeare, *Julius Caesar*

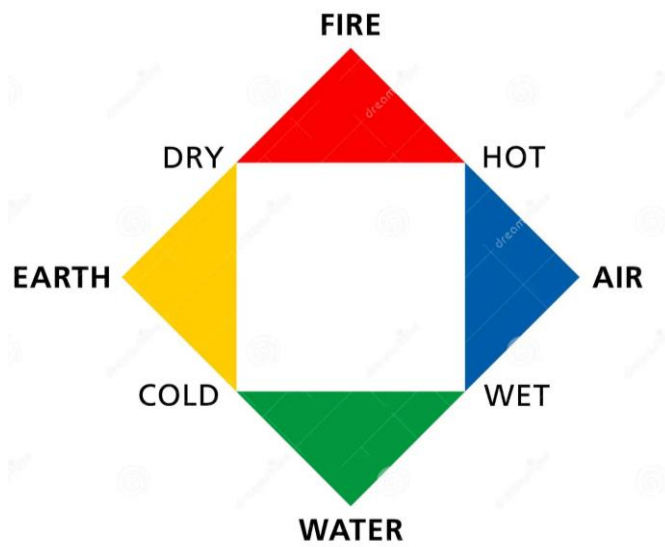
2.1 Pre-Socratic Philosophy and the Four Elements

Before Socrates, Greek thinkers were already asking a different kind of question — not who created the world, but what it was made of. Empedocles of Akragas (circa 490-430 BCE) proposed an answer that held for nearly two thousand years: all matter is composed of four eternal roots — fire, water, air, and earth (Kirk, Raven and Schofield, 1983). These roots do not change; what changes is how they mix. Everything in the observable world is a different proportion of the same four ingredients, drawn together by Love (philia) and pulled apart by Strife (neikos).

Each element carries its own qualities. Fire (south) — courage, initiative, the danger of acting before thinking. Water (west) — compassion, adaptability, the risk of avoidance. Air (east) — intellect, curiosity, the challenge of indecision. Earth (north) — patience, discipline, the risk of rigidity (Aristotle, *On Generation and Corruption*). These profiles became Rhizomata's Identity Cards directly. Each element also carries a classical geometric symbol — upward triangle for fire, downward for water, horizontal-barred variants for air and earth — used as space-type markers on the game board.



[Figure 2.1: *The Classical Four-Elements Wheel*]



[Figure 2.2: Elemental Qualities — Hot, Cold, Wet, and Dry]

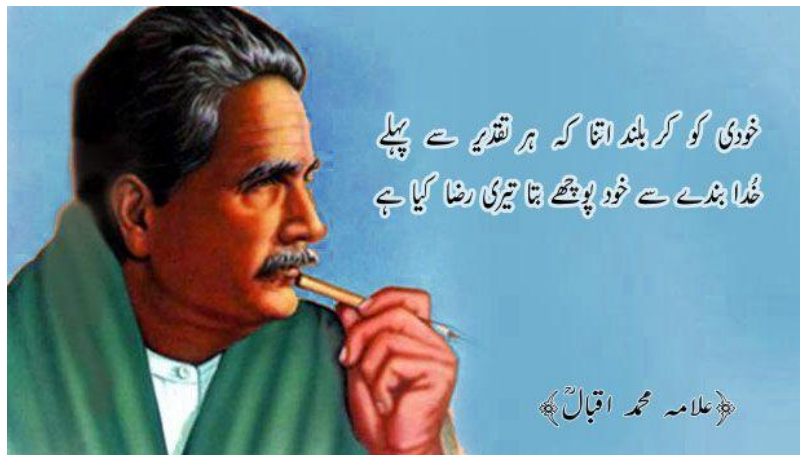
The same four elements also form the foundation of the Western zodiac tradition, which groups all twelve signs into elemental triplicities: Fire (Aries, Leo, Sagittarius), Earth (Taurus, Virgo, Capricorn), Air (Gemini, Libra, Aquarius), and Water (Cancer, Scorpio, Pisces). Astrological tradition holds that the element of a person's birth sign shapes their fundamental personality and influences the course of their life. This is precisely the interpretation that Rhizomata challenges. In the zodiac framework, your element is assigned at birth — fixed, inherited, and beyond your control. In Rhizomata, the element is dealt randomly at the start of the game, but what the player does with it is entirely a matter of choice. The game deliberately draws on the same symbolic vocabulary as the zodiac — the same four elements, the same qualities, the same archetypal tensions — and then inverts the zodiac's central assumption: that these forces act upon us. Rhizomata's position, grounded in Empedocles' original philosophy and in the moral frameworks of Islam, Iqbal, and classical literature, is the opposite: we act through them. The element is a starting condition, not a sentence. As Shakespeare wrote in *Julius Caesar*, "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves." Rhizomata was built to put that challenge directly in a player's hands.



[Figure 2.3: Elemental Triplicities in the Western Zodiac]

2.2 Moral Duality in Philosophy and Culture

The tension between who we want to be and who we actually become in moments of pressure — this appears in almost every serious philosophical tradition. In Empedocles' cosmology, this is expressed as the perpetual tension between Love and Strife within every individual mixture. Allama Iqbal built his philosophy of Khudi — the self — on this exact foundation: the ego either develops through action and moral effort, or it shrinks through passivity (Iqbal, 1920). His verse — "Khudi ko kar buland itna ke har taqdeer se pehle, Khuda bande se khud poochhe, bata teri raza kya hai" (Iqbal, 1915) — is the aspiration behind Rhizomata's Stability Pawn: a self raised so high through its own choices that even destiny must ask its permission.

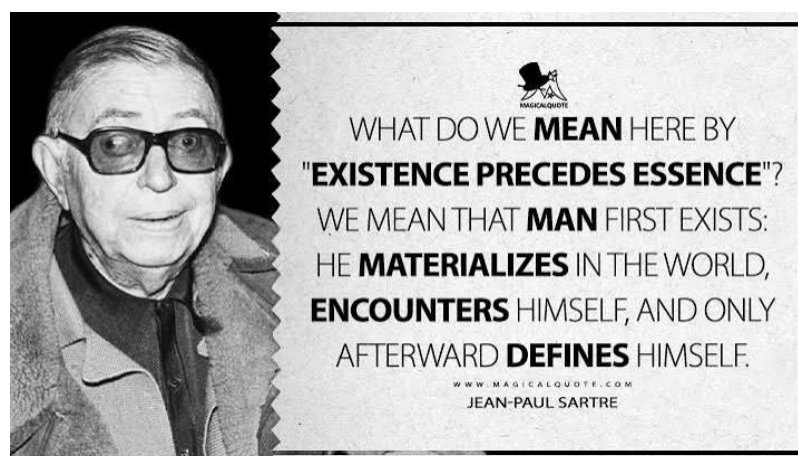


[Figure 2.4: Allama Iqbal — Khudi Couplet]

The Quran articulates the same framework. "There is not for man except that for which he strives" (53:39); "Allah would not change a person's state until they change their own state" (13:11); "Every person is a hostage to what they have earned" (74:38). The Prophet's hadith — "Tie your camel, then put your trust in Allah" — captures the game's structure exactly: the rules are fixed and fair, but what happens within them is entirely up to the player. Shakespeare arrives at the same conclusion from a different direction: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, but in ourselves" (Julius Caesar). Separated by centuries and continents, these traditions say the same thing. Destiny is not given. It is chosen.

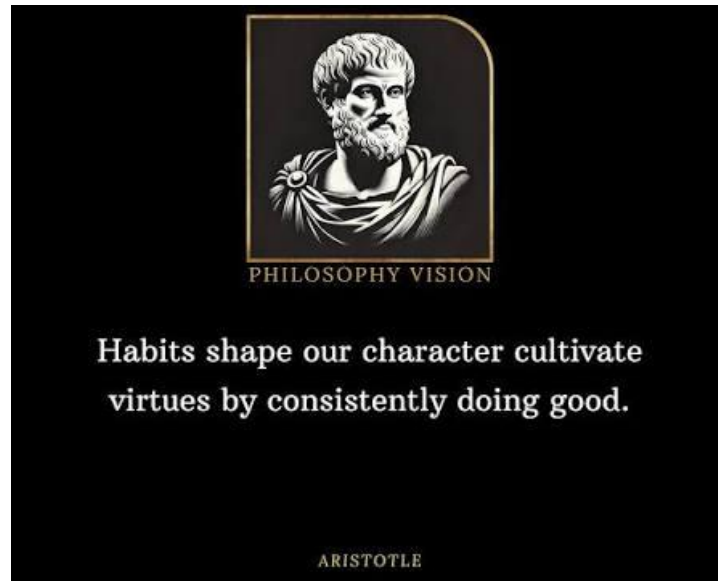
2.3 Western Philosophy: Agency and Self-Creation

Three Western philosophers speak directly to Rhizomata's core argument. Sartre's 'existence precedes essence' means exactly what Rhizomata enacts: there is no fixed human type, no assigned archetype (Sartre, 1945). You define yourself through what you choose. The Archetype Reveal is a Sartrean moment — you did not start as The Sage, you became one. Nietzsche's self-overcoming is the logic behind the Stability Pawn: it advances only through repeated restraint against something more immediately rewarding (Nietzsche, 1883). Not one heroic act — the accumulation of small ones.



[Figure 2.5: Jean-Paul Sartre — "Existence Precedes Essence"]

Aristotle completes the framework. In the *Nicomachean Ethics*, virtue is not a quality you have — it is a habit built through doing (Aristotle, circa 350 BCE). 'We become just by doing just acts, brave by doing brave acts.' That is the exact logic of the token economy. A Balance Token is a record of having chosen one kind of action over another. Collect enough, and they stop being a record. They become a character.



[Figure 2.6: Aristotle — Virtue as Habit]

2.4 Modern Board Games and Moral Decision-Making

The most relevant precedents for *Rhizomata* are not resource or strategy games — they are games that made moral weight their primary mechanic. Reiner Knizia argues that the heart of any good game is a meaningful decision where multiple options are genuinely viable (Knizia, 2000). That principle shaped *Rhizomata*'s card rule: both options must be genuinely tempting. If one is obviously better, the card fails. Jamey Stegmaier writes about the human element of design — the experience a player carries away, not just the mechanics they interacted with (Stegmaier, 2020). A game ending with a feeling gives a player a memory. That is why *Rhizomata* ends with an Archetype, not a score.

The *King's Dilemma* (2019, Horrible Guild) is the closest commercial precedent: every governance decision leaves a permanent record in the game's physical chronicle. You

cannot undo what you chose. The same permanence defines Rhizomata's token economy — every token stays, regardless of what comes later. This War of Mine: The Board Game (2017, Awaken Realms) proved players will engage with genuine moral difficulty; it shows consequences without labelling them right or wrong. Fog of Love (2017, Hush Hush Projects) demonstrated that a board game can carry the interiority of fiction — real questions, genuinely uncertain answers. Rhizomata works from all three of these premises simultaneously.

2.5 Choice, Agency, and Transparency in Game Design

Greg Costikyan (1994) argues that what makes games engaging is not chance, but meaningful uncertainty — the kind that comes from the quality of your decisions. Jesse Schell (2008) suggests the best games balance luck and skill just enough that choices feel real. Rhizomata goes further: it removes chance from consequences entirely. The draw is random; what happens after you decide is not. Miguel Sicart (2009) makes the point that genuine moral experience in games does not come from hidden outcomes — it comes from real conflict between things you actually value. That is exactly what Rhizomata's card writing tries to create.

CHAPTER 3 METHODS AND MATERIALS

*Amal se zindagi banti hai jannat bhi jahannum bhi — Yeh khaki apni fitrat mein na noori
hai na naari hai.*

— Allama Muhammad Iqbal

3.1 Research Design

This project uses Design-Based Research (DBR) — a methodology built on iterative cycles of design, testing, and redesign (Brown, 1992). It suits this project well because the goal was never just to produce an artifact. It was to learn from building it. The process ran across twelve months in three phases: conceptual development and research (Months 1-3), prototype development and playtesting (Months 4-8), and final design and documentation (Months 9-12).

3.2 Research Approach

The research uses both qualitative and quantitative methods. During each session, the researcher observed play without intervening — noting moments of engagement, confusion, or unexpected social response. After each session, participants completed a six-item Likert survey (1-5 scale). Throughout the design process, the MDA framework (Hunicke, LeBlanc and Zubek, 2004) was used as a diagnostic tool: if the mechanics are right, the dynamics follow, and the intended emotional experience emerges. When playtesting revealed gaps between what the rules said and what players actually felt, the mechanics were revised.

3.3 Data Collection

Five playtesting sessions were conducted at the Institute of Art and Design, GCUF, with four participants per session (total n=20). Participants were recruited voluntarily from the student body, aged 18-24 (14 female, 6 male). Each session included a 10-minute rules

explanation, a complete game (50-75 minutes), and a 15-minute post-game survey and discussion. All participants completed an informed consent form before the session.

The post-game survey measured six items:

- The game was enjoyable to play.
- The rules were clear and easy to follow.
- The balance between chance and strategy felt appropriate.
- My decisions felt meaningful and impactful.
- The game felt fair, even when random events occurred.
- I would play this game again.

3.4 Timeline

Phase	Months	Activity
1 — Research	1–3	Pre-Socratic research, concept development, Game Design Document
2 — Prototype v1	4–5	First playable prototype; sessions 1 & 2; removed Consequence Cards and Shadow Track
2 — Prototype v2	6–7	Revised token economy and Encounter mechanic; sessions 3 & 4; rulebook revision
2 — Prototype v3	8	Final visual design; session 5
3 — Final	9–12	Analysis, documentation, and thesis writing

CHAPTER 4 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION

Destiny is not a matter of chance; it is a matter of choice.

— William Jennings Bryan

4.1 Survey Results

Table 4.1 presents the post-game survey results across all five sessions (n=20).

Table 4.1: Post-Game Survey Results (n = 20)

Survey Item	Mean (1-5)	SD
The game was enjoyable to play.	4.35	0.67
The rules were clear and easy to follow.	3.90	0.85
Balance between chance and strategy felt right.	4.15	0.75
My decisions felt meaningful and impactful.	4.50	0.61
The game felt fair even when random events occurred.	4.20	0.70
I would play this game again.	4.40	0.68
Overall Mean	4.27	0.60

"My decisions felt meaningful and impactful" was the highest-scoring item (M = 4.50, SD = 0.61) — the most direct test of whether the transparency mechanic works. The lowest score was rule clarity (M = 3.90), tracking a specific confusion around the Encounter mechanic that a rulebook revision resolved between sessions 3 and 4.

Not all responses were uniformly positive. A minority of participants — three out of twenty — indicated they would have preferred a traditional competitive win condition, and felt the Archetype Reveal reduced the sense of victory at the end of the game. Two participants found the moral deliberation slower than expected, describing certain Situation Cards as requiring too much cognitive effort in a social setting. These responses are noted

as design limitations and point toward a potential optional competitive mode for future development.

4.2 Key Observations

Across five sessions, four patterns were consistent enough to shape the final design:

Knowing still did not make it easy. Players consistently described the choices as genuinely hard, even with full information. One participant from session 3 put it directly: "I knew exactly what would happen if I took the shortcut and I chose it anyway. That bothered me more than if I had just rolled badly." Average deliberation time before each decision was approximately 22 seconds — longer than the researcher expected.

The Encounter mechanic — a silent, immediate Welcome or Reject decision with no discussion permitted — was consistently the most memorable social moment of every session. Players were surprised by what a small, fast decision revealed about someone they thought they knew.

The end-game Archetype Reveal consistently prompted genuine self-reflection. One player from session 5 said: "I thought I had been playing carefully all game, but my Archetype came out as The Opportunist. I think I underestimated how much the small shortcuts add up." Some version of that moment — surprise at one's own accumulated choices — happened in all five sessions.

The Sacrifice mechanic — permanently removing tokens from your own pile for a powerful effect — was used in four of five sessions and generated the most emotionally memorable moments of the playtesting period. Sacrificed tokens are removed from scoring entirely, making it a genuine trade. The Archetype Reveal that closes the game reinforced this: after tallying tokens and pawn positions, each player receives a named identity — The

Sage, The Rebel, The Guardian, The Wanderer, The Opportunist. No winner, no loser. Players leave with a character, not a number.

Session length also exceeded projections in a useful way. Average game time across sessions was 72 minutes, within the 60-90 minute target, but deliberation per decision averaged 22 seconds — longer than the 15-20 seconds initially projected. Players were not confused; they were genuinely conflicted. Several described pausing not because they did not understand the options, but because both options felt uncomfortably accurate. That two-second gap between estimate and reality is one of the most encouraging findings in the dataset.

4.3 Archetype Scoring System

The Archetype Reveal is not a gut feeling or a discussion. It is calculated. A fixed two-axis system, applied after final scoring, places every player into one of five Archetypes. Those five outcomes are not arbitrary — they are the five meaningfully distinct positions a player can reach based on how they played.

Axis 1 is the Token Ratio (T) — Balance Tokens divided by total tokens, as a percentage. 65% or above: Balance-dominant. Below 40%: Pressure-dominant. Between 40% and 64%: Mixed.

Axis 2 is Pawn Divergence (P) — Stability Pawn position minus Ambition Pawn position. A difference of +5 or more means Stability-led. -5 or less means Ambition-led. Anything within 4 spaces either way is Even.

Table 4.2: Archetype Classification Matrix

Token Ratio (T)	Stability-Led ($P \geq +5$)	Even (-4 to $+4$)	Ambition-Led ($P \leq -5$)
Balance-Dominant ($T \geq 65\%$)	THE SAGE	THE GUARDIAN	THE WANDERER
Mixed ($40\% \leq T < 65\%$)	THE GUARDIAN	THE WANDERER	THE REBEL
Pressure-Dominant ($T < 40\%$)	THE OPPORTUNIST	THE REBEL	THE REBEL

Example: Player ends with 8 Balance Tokens, 3 Pressure Tokens. Stability Pawn on space 28, Ambition Pawn on space 16. $T = 8/11 = 72.7\% \rightarrow$ Balance-Dominant. $P = 28 - 16 = +12 \rightarrow$ Stability-Led. Archetype: THE SAGE.

The five Archetypes cover every meaningful outcome. The Sage: consistent restraint, Stability-led. The Guardian: balanced, deliberate. The Wanderer: mixed choices with an ambition lean. The Rebel: bold, Pressure-heavy, Ambition-led. The Opportunist — the most psychologically interesting result — high Pressure accumulation but the Stability Pawn still leads. They took risks and avoided consequences. Whether that reads as cleverness or avoidance is left to the player.

CHAPTER 5 FINAL DESIGN PROJECT

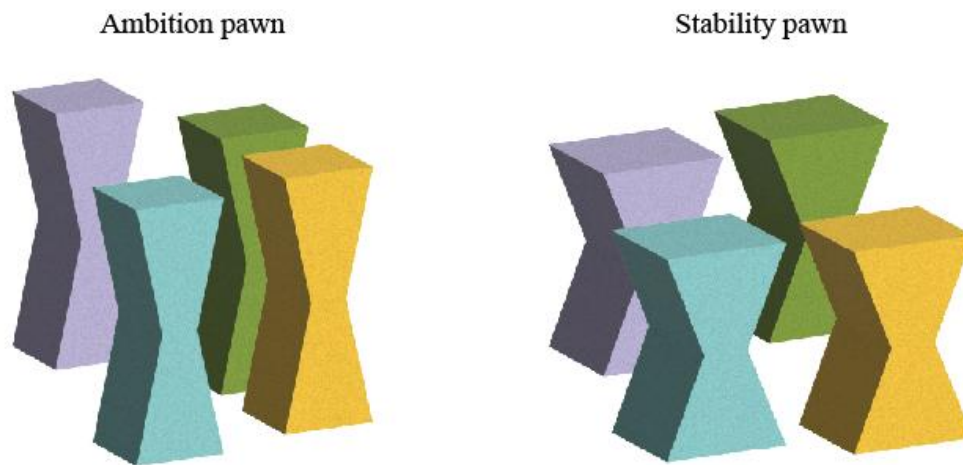
5.1 Final Game Design

Rhizomata is a complete, playable tabletop board game for 2-4 players, ages 13 and above, with an average session length of 72 minutes. The complete game consists of: 1 laminated 20×20 inch game board, 4 Identity Cards (tarot size, illustrated), 4 Stability Pawns and 4 Ambition Pawns (colour-coded to element), 60 Situation Cards and 42 Context Cards (bridge size 63×88mm, 102 cards total), Token counting system, and a complete rulebook.

The game is fully self-contained — nothing extra needed. Setup runs about five minutes; rules explanation for first-time players takes around ten. Every component carries the same visual language: the elemental symbols appear on the Identity Cards, the board space markers, and the section headers of the rulebook. The philosophy is not just described in the rules. It is present in the design of every piece.

The rulebook was treated as a design component, not a supplementary document. At 16 pages, it follows the game's visual language throughout — elemental symbols divide sections, the colour system is consistent, and the writing is direct rather than legalistic. Game rules are difficult to write well. The goal is always to answer the question a player has not yet thought to ask. The first two rulebook versions answered the questions players did ask, which is precisely why they kept being revised. The final version was written with five sessions of knowledge about exactly what confused people and why.

PAWNS

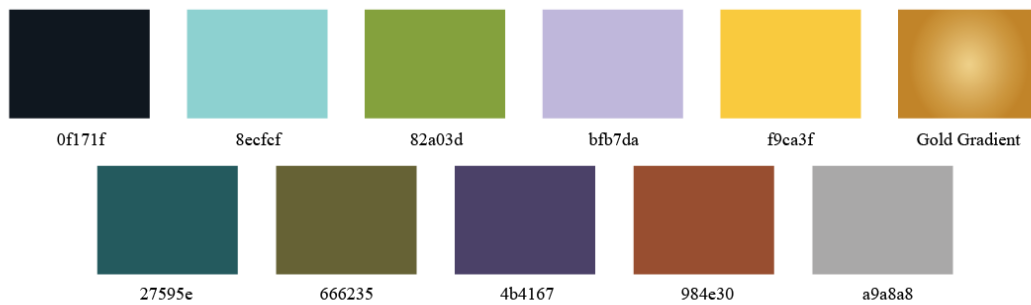


[Figure 5.1: Final Game Components — Pawns]

5.2 Visual Design

The visual system uses four elemental colours: red-orange for Fire, deep blue for Water, deep purple for Air, warm brown-green for Earth. The classical triangle glyphs — adapted with contemporary line weight — run across every component as the primary visual language. Typography pairs a serif body face with a geometric display face. Identity Card artwork renders each element abstractly: Fire ascending, Water as contained depth, Air expanding outward, Earth anchored. Situation Cards use a clean two-column layout with consequences in a lighter weight — description and outcome visually distinct at a glance.

COLOR PALLETE



TYPOGRAPHY

THE WILD BREATH OF ZELDA

CINZEL

Californian FB

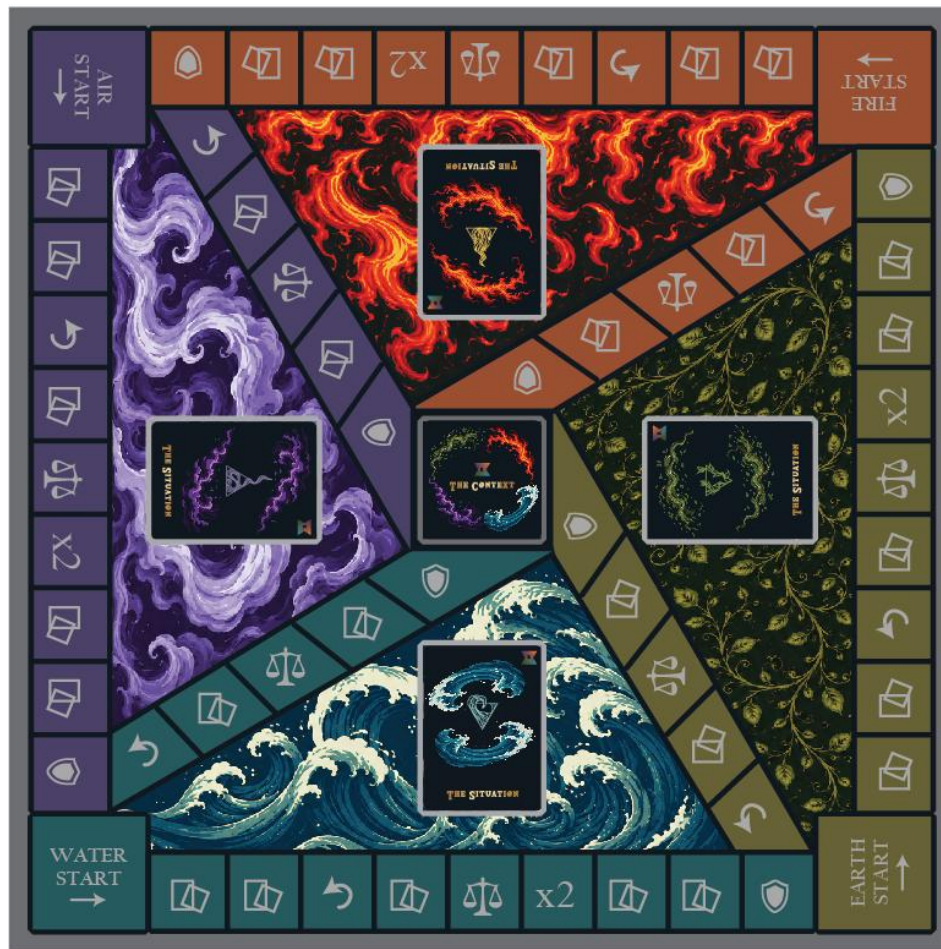
[Figure 5.2: Visual Identity — Color Palette and Typography]

To strengthen the project’s visual identity beyond the physical game, a dedicated promotional website was also designed. The website presents the game’s philosophy, gameplay, visual identity, and key features while serving as a central platform for introducing Rhizomata to potential players and future audiences.

The promotional campaign includes a series of launch posters, social media branding, and digital promotional assets developed using the same visual language as the game components. The campaign introduces Rhizomata’s core message — “Destiny is not given. It is chosen.” — while maintaining consistency across print and digital media.



[Figure 5.3: Final Identity Cards — Full Set]



[Figure 5.4: Game Board — Final Print-Ready Layout]



[Figure 5.5: Final Situation Cards — Front and Back, All Four Elements]



[Figure 5.6: Final Context Card — Back and Sample Front]

CONCLUSIONS

Rhizomata set out to test a specific proposition: that visible consequences can replace hidden consequences as the primary source of tension in a game. This is not a cosmetic design choice — it is a structural one. It requires removing dice, removing hidden outcome cards, and trusting that the difficulty of choosing between two options whose full consequences are already known is enough to sustain genuine engagement across sixty to ninety minutes of play. Five sessions, twenty participants, and a mean satisfaction score of 4.27 out of 5.00 later — it is enough.

Empedocles' framework did not provide a theme — it provided architecture. Every system traces back to the same philosophical logic: Identity Cards, dual-pawn mechanic, token economy, Archetype Reveal. Players who had never heard of Empedocles still experienced it as meaningful, because consistent logic has a feeling. You can tell when something is not arbitrary.

The Dual-Self mechanic — controlling both a Stability Pawn and an Ambition Pawn simultaneously — produced the most consistent finding of the playtesting series: players were surprised by their Archetype reveal. The identity reveal replaced the conventional score announcement, and this shift proved significant. Players did not leave saying "I won" or "I lost." They left saying "I became The Rebel" or "I became The Sage." The game did not judge them. It reflected the record of their own choices.

That is what Rhizomata was built to do. As Iqbal wrote: the self is not given. It is built — or diminished — by every choice. As the Quran states: "Allah would not change a

people's state until they change their own state" (13:11). Every turn in this game is a small version of that question. Over sixty to ninety minutes, the small questions accumulate. And at the end, the board shows you who you became.

As a BFA Graphic Design project, Rhizomata also makes a claim about what graphic design can be. The visual system — the elemental colour palette, the glyph system, the typography, the card layout — is not an illustration of the philosophy. It is the philosophy made visible. When every visual decision and every mechanical decision trace back to the same source, the result is not a themed game. It is a coherent one. Design can do that. It can take an abstract idea — that identity is built through accumulated choices, not assigned at birth — and give it a form that a person can hold, play for an hour, and walk away having experienced rather than simply understood. That is what this project set out to do. That is what design is for.

Next steps for Rhizomata include broader playtesting across different age groups and backgrounds, finalising the full 102-card deck through targeted card-level testing, and taking the visual design to production quality. A digital version on Tabletop Simulator would allow wider testing and serve as a demonstration tool for any future campaign.

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